25 Mark Essay Planner

Notes and bullet points only. Fill every box and you have your essay plan.

The question

Key idea AO1 is worth 5 marks: explain the theory briefly and precisely. AO2 is worth 20 marks: argue, weigh up, and reach a conclusion. Plan your time the same way.

Box 01 Introduction

Say what you will argue

My contention One clear sentence that answers the question. Take a side. *In this essay I shall argue that ...*	
Key terms Define only the terms the question turns on. *By [term] I mean ...*	
My route The order of the objections you will test your contention against.	

Box 02 AO1 · Analysis

Introduce the theory · 5 marks

The theory What does it claim? Who holds it? State it accurately, in your own words. *[Thinker] holds that ...*	
The argument for it Why would anyone believe it? Set the reasoning out in steps. *(i) ... (ii) ... so (iii) ...*	

Example or illustration

One example that makes the theory clear. No evaluation yet.

Box 03 AO2 · Evaluation: Objection 1

Objection → response → counter-response

Objection

What is the problem? Who raises it? Which claim does it attack?

However, it may be objected that ...

Response

How would a defender of the theory reply?

This objection assumes ..., but ...

Counter-response

Does the reply work? Push back, or show why it holds.

Even if this is granted, ...

Intermediate conclusion

Who wins? What does this do to your contention?

So far, then, ... because ...

Bridge ↓

Objection 1 → Objection 2

How does the next one follow on?

☐ It attacks the reply just given ☐ It is a stronger version of the same worry

☐ It grants this point but attacks another claim ☐ It is a new line of attack

Even if ..., a further problem is ...

Box 04 AO2 · Evaluation: Objection 2

Objection → response → counter-response

Objection

What is the problem? Who raises it? Which claim does it attack?

However, it may be objected that ...

Response

How would a defender of the theory reply?

This objection assumes ..., but ...

Counter-response

Does the reply work? Push back, or show why it holds.

Even if this is granted, ...

Intermediate conclusion

Who wins? What does this do to your contention?

So far, then, ... because ...

Bridge ↓

Objection 2 → Objection 3

How does the next one follow on?

☐ It attacks the reply just given ☐ It is a stronger version of the same worry

☐ It grants this point but attacks another claim ☐ It is a new line of attack

Even if ..., a further problem is ...

Box 05 AO2 · Evaluation: Objection 3

Objection → response → counter-response

Objection

What is the problem? Who raises it? Which claim does it attack?

However, it may be objected that ...

Response

How would a defender of the theory reply?

This objection assumes ..., but ...

Counter-response

Does the reply work? Push back, or show why it holds.

Even if this is granted, ...

Intermediate conclusion

Who wins? What does this do to your contention?

So far, then, ... because ...

Bridge ↓

Objection 3 → Objection 4

How does the next one follow on?

☐ It attacks the reply just given ☐ It is a stronger version of the same worry

☐ It grants this point but attacks another claim ☐ It is a new line of attack

Even if ..., a further problem is ...

Box 06

AO2 · Evaluation: Objection 4

Objection → response → counter-response

Objection

What is the problem? Who raises it? Which claim does it attack?

However, it may be objected that ...

Response

How would a defender of the theory reply?

This objection assumes ..., but ...

Counter-response

Does the reply work? Push back, or show why it holds.

Even if this is granted, ...

Intermediate conclusion

Who wins? What does this do to your contention?

So far, then, ... because ...

Bridge ↓

Objections → Conclusion

Weigh them up first.

☐ Most serious: Objection ____ ☐ Least serious: Objection ____

The most serious objection is ... because ...

Box 07

Conclusion

Restate your contention · add nothing new

My contention, restated

Say it again, now with the detail you have earned.

Exactly which version of the claim survives?

In conclusion, my contention that ... stands / does not stand.

The strongest reason

The one argument your conclusion rests on.

The strongest reason for this is ...

The most serious objection	
Name it, and say in a line why it fails (or why it succeeds). *The most serious objection was ..., but ...*	

Your argument at a glance

Write three or four words in each cell. Read across: if it makes one line of thought, your essay has a structure.

Contention →	Objection 1 →	Objection 2 →	Objection 3 →	Objection 4 →	Conclusion

Before you start writing

- ☐ My contention is one sentence, and my conclusion matches it.
- ☐ My AO1 is short and precise: only what the evaluation needs.
- ☐ Every AO2 box ends in an intermediate conclusion with a 'because'.
- ☐ Every bridge says how one objection leads to the next.
- ☐ I have said which objection matters most, and why.

Golden rule Never write 'this is a strong argument' without finishing the sentence with 'because ...'. The reason is where the marks are.